

An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge

Ambrose Bierce · 1890

First published: San Francisco Examiner, Jul 1890

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

AP edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Claude Monet, The Magpie (1868–1869). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Collected_Works_of_Ambrose_Bierce/Volume_2/An_Occurrence_at_Owl_Creek_Bridge (revision 7797523), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge suggest about illusion and reality?
- What does An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge suggest about war and death?
- What does An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge suggest about time?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: AP

AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN

AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*illusion and reality* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge

Author biography

Ambrose Bierce was born in Meigs County, Ohio, on 24 June 1842. He fought for the Union in the Civil War, at Shiloh and Chickamauga, and was seriously wounded in the head at Kennesaw Mountain in 1864. Afterwards he became a sharp-tongued San Francisco journalist and columnist, known as "Bitter Bierce," and wrote war stories and ghost stories collected in Tales of Soldiers and Civilians (1891) and the satirical Devil's Dictionary (1906; 1911). In late 1913 he travelled into revolutionary Mexico and disappeared; his fate is unknown.

Historical and cultural context

The story is set in northern Alabama during the American Civil War (1861–1865). Union forces held railroads in the region and executed civilians caught sabotaging them. Bierce had fought for the Union at Shiloh and Chickamauga, and his war stories are known for their unsentimental view of death.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in the San Francisco Examiner on 13 July 1890; collected in Tales of Soldiers and Civilians (1891, later retitled In the Midst of Life).

Then: Admired by a limited audience; Bierce's grim war fiction did not sell widely.

Now: One of the most famous American short stories, a landmark of non-linear structure and the twist ending; Robert Enrico's French film adaptation (1962) won an Academy Award and aired on The Twilight Zone in 1964.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Peyton Farquhar, a Southern planter, is about to be hanged from a railroad bridge by Union soldiers. The story moves back in time to explain why, then follows him as the rope breaks and he tries to escape home to his wife.

Main themes

- perception and time.
- the romance and reality of war.
- illusion versus reality.

Why it matters

Students learn to track point of view and time shifts, and to question narrators, skills useful for film as well as fiction.

Spoilers · teacher only

The escape takes place only in his mind in the moments before death; the final line reveals his body hanging from the bridge.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge: How can a second feel like an hour? Describe a moment when time seemed to slow.
Prompt: Before we open An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge: How can a second feel like an hour? Describe a moment when time seemed to slow.

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

point of view (objective, limited); flashback; stream of consciousness; foreshadowing; twist ending.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Ambrose Bierce was born in Meigs County, Ohio, on 24 June 1842. He fought for the Union in the Civil War, at Shiloh and Chickamauga, and was seriously wounded in the head at Kennesaw Mountain in 1864. Afterwards he became a sharp-tongued San Francisco journalist and columnist, known as "Bitter Bierce," and wrote war stories and ghost stories collected in Tales of Soldiers and Civilians (1891) and the satirical Devil's Dictionary (1906; 1911). In late 1913 he travelled into revolutionary Mexico and disappeared; his fate is unknown. The world of the book. The story is set in northern Alabama during the American Civil War (1861–1865). Union forces held railroads in the region and executed civilians caught sabotaging them. Bierce had fought for the Union at Shiloh and Chickamauga, and his war stories are known for their unsentimental view of death. Publication and reception. First published in the San Francisco Examiner on 13 July 1890; collected in Tales of Soldiers and Civilians (1891, later retitled In the Midst of Life). Then: Admired by a limited audience; Bierce's grim war fiction did not sell widely. Now: One of the most famous American short stories, a landmark of non-linear structure and the twist ending; Robert Enrico's French film adaptation (1962) won an Academy Award and aired on The Twilight Zone in 1964.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"Peyton Farquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side beneath the timbers of the Owl Creek bridge" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37). The final sentence.

> *Peyton Farquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side beneath the timbers of the Owl Creek bridge (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37)*

Think-aloud: "Peyton Farquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side beneath the timbers of the Owl Creek bridge" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37). The final sentence.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Peyton Farquhar, a Southern planter, is about to be hanged from a railroad bridge by Union soldiers. The story moves back in time to explain why, then follows him as the rope breaks and he tries to escape home to his wife. Themes to track: perception and time.: the romance and reality of war.: illusion versus reality.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge still matter? Students learn to track point of view and time shifts, and to question narrators, skills useful for film as well as fiction.
Anchor question: Why might An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge still be taught today?
Facilitation: Students learn to track point of view and time shifts, and to question narrators, skills useful for film as well as fiction.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Name one clue that the escape is not real. Answer: Examples: his heightened senses, the strange perfect road, his neck pain, the "stunning blow upon the back of the neck."
Exit ticket: Name one clue that the escape is not real.
Answer: Examples: his heightened senses, the strange perfect road, his neck pain, the "stunning blow upon the back of the neck."

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Ambrose Bierce" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Ambrose-Bierce); Ambrose Bierce Project (https://www.ambrosebierce.org/); Library of America, Bierce: The Devil's Dictionary, Tales & Memoirs (https://www.loa.org/books/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Content note: execution by hanging; Farquhar is a slave owner and a supporter of the Confederacy, which the text states plainly.

Lesson 2: An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge

Focus: the mind's final escape at the moment of death

Objective: Students will analyze how structure develops in "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: CCSS RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4 · IN 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (execution by hanging, civil war violence): Sensitive content: Execution by hanging; Civil War violence. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes execution by hanging; Civil War violence.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Peyton Farquhar, a Southern planter, stands on a railroad bridge in Alabama about to be hanged by Union soldiers. Part II flashes back: a disguised Union scout tempted him to try burning the bridge. In Part III the rope seems to break; he swims, dodges bullets, and walks all night to his home, where his wife waits. As he reaches for her, a blow falls: he is dead, his body swinging beneath the bridge.

Background: Bierce fought for the Union at Shiloh and Chickamauga; the story (1890) is in Tales of Soldiers and Civilians.

Significance: A celebrated experiment with time and point of view; the twist depends on shifting from objective to subjective narration.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Time can feel slow or fast. When has a moment seemed to last forever? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to perception and time because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes execution by hanging; Civil War violence.
Prompt: Time can feel slow or fast. When has a moment seemed to last forever?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to perception and time because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the whole escape happens in a moment.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: engulfed — swallowed up completely; pitilessly — without pity or mercy; inhaled — breathed in; smashing — breaking into pieces; carpeted — covered as if with a carpet. "pitilessly": From Middle English piteeles, pyteles; equivalent to pity + less. "inhaled": From Latin inhalare "to breathe on (breathe in)", from in "in, into, on" + halare "to breathe".
Words: engulfed: swallowed up completely · pitilessly: without pity or mercy · inhaled: breathed in · smashing: breaking into pieces · carpeted: covered as if with a carpet

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Bierce fought for the Union at Shiloh and Chickamauga; the story (1890) is in Tales of Soldiers and Civilians. A celebrated experiment with time and point of view; the twist depends on shifting from objective to subjective narration. Structure: Three parts: the present (the execution), a flashback (the scout's trap), and the escape, which turns out to be imagined. Point of view: Part I is objective, like a camera; Part III moves deep into Farquhar's mind, so the reader shares his illusion. Foreshadowing: The ticking watch, his heightened senses and the dream-like road all hint that the escape is unreal. Watch for the bridge: the line between life and death.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "What he heard was the ticking of his watch" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5). Slowed time. That is structure at work: Three parts: the present (the execution), a flashback (the scout's trap), and the escape, which turns out to be imagined.

> *What he heard was the ticking of his watch (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "What he heard was the ticking of his watch" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5). Slowed time. That is structure at work: Three parts: the present (the execution), a flashback (the scout's trap), and the escape, which turns out to be imagined.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The rope. Look at the craft: Part I is objective, like a camera; Part III moves deep into Farquhar's mind, so the reader shares his illusion. Ask: How does this line connect to perception and time? Expected: The whole escape happens in a moment. (The rope.)

> *As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The rope. Look at the craft: Part I is objective, like a camera; Part III moves deep into Farquhar's mind, so the reader shares his illusion.
Ask: How does this line connect to perception and time?
Expected answer: The whole escape happens in a moment. (The rope.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for structure, point of view (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge develops the idea of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. When the text says "As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36), it shows this directly. Part III stays in his mind, with heightened sound ("What he heard was the ticking of his watch"); the switch to the present tense ("As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow") and the objective last line expose the illusion.
Task: Annotate the story for structure, point of view (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge develops the idea of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. When the text says "As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36), it shows this directly. Part III stays in his mind, with heightened sound ("What he heard was the ticking of his watch"); the switch to the present tense ("As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow") and the objective last line expose the illusion.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Time can feel slow or fast. When has a moment seemed to last forever? Ask: why might Bierce make the escape so beautiful? What does it say about war?
Anchor question: Time can feel slow or fast. When has a moment seemed to last forever?
Facilitation: Ask: why might Bierce make the escape so beautiful? What does it say about war?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. ("As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck", An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. ("As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck", An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how structure shapes the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Key takeaway: the whole escape happens in a moment.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Structure:** Three parts: the present (the execution), a flashback (the scout's trap), and the escape, which turns out to be imagined.
- **Point of view:** Part I is objective, like a camera; Part III moves deep into Farquhar's mind, so the reader shares his illusion.
- **Foreshadowing:** The ticking watch, his heightened senses and the dream-like road all hint that the escape is unreal.

Themes and how they develop

- **perception and time:** the whole escape happens in a moment.

Symbols and motifs

- **the bridge:** the line between life and death.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "What he heard was the ticking of his watch" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5) Slowed time.
- "As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36) The rope.
- "Peyton Farquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37) The reality.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion.
Evidence: "As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36)
Reasoning: Part III stays in his mind, with heightened sound ("What he heard was the ticking of his watch"); the switch to the present tense ("As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow") and the objective last line expose the illusion.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
engulfed (verb)	swallowed up completely	*He felt his head emerge; his eyes were blinded by the sunlight; his chest expanded convulsively, and with a supreme and crowning agony his lungs engulfed a great draught of air, which instantly he expelled in a shriek!*	
pitilessly (adverb)	without pity or mercy	*How coldly and pitilessly—with what an even, calm intonation, presaging, and enforcing tranquillity in the men—with what accurately measured intervals fell those cruel words:*	"pitilessly": From Middle English piteeles, pyteles; equivalent to pity + less. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/pitiless#Etymology)
inhaled (verb)	breathed in	*The trees upon the bank were giant garden plants; he noted a definite order in their arrangement, inhaled the fragrance of their blooms.*	"inhaled": From Latin inhalare "to breathe on (breathe in)", from in "in, into, on" + halare "to breathe". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/inhale#Etymology)
smashing (noun)	breaking into pieces	*As he shook his head free from the commotion of the smitten water he heard the deflected shot humming through the air*	

		ahead, and in an instant it was cracking and smashing the branches in the forest beyond.	
carpeted (verb)	covered as if with a carpet	*How softly the turf had carpeted the untraveled avenue—he could no longer feel the roadway beneath his feet!*	
maddening (adjective)	driving one wild	*The intervals of silence grew progressively longer; the delays became maddening.*	
singsong (noun)	a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation	*The sound of a clear, high voice in a monotonous singsong now rang out behind him and came across the water with a distinctness that pierced and subdued all other sounds, even the beating of the ripples in his ears.*	"singsong": From sing + song. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/singsong#Etymology)
assassin (noun)	a murderer	*Evidently this was no vulgar assassin.*	"assassin": From either French assassin or Italian assassino, from Arabic أَسَاسِيِّين "people who are faithful to the foundation [of the faith]" and the folkloric etymology Arabic حَشَّاشِين "hashish users; low-lives". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/assassin#Etymology)
etiquette (noun)	rules governing socially acceptable behavior	*In the code of military etiquette silence and fixity are forms of deference.*	
insupportable (adjective)	unbearable	*His whole body was racked and wrenched with an insupportable anguish!*	"insupportable": From Middle French insupportable, from Late Latin insupportabilis. See also in + supportable. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/insupportable#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. Time can feel slow or fast. When has a moment seemed to last forever?
2. Where does structure appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with illusion and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1,

2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Where is Farquhar at the start? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: On a railroad bridge about to be hanged
2. Why is he being executed? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: He tried to interfere with the railroad bridge
3. Who tempted him to attack the bridge? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: A Federal scout disguised as a Confederate soldier
4. What does Farquhar seem to experience in Part III? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: An escape home to his wife
5. What is the truth at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: He has died by hanging
6. Retell the three most important events of "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: Peyton Farquhar, a Southern planter, stands on a railroad bridge in Alabama about to be hanged by Union soldiers. Part II flashes back: a disguised Union scout tempted him to try burning the bridge. In Part III the rope seems to break; he swims, dodges bullets, and walks all night to his home, where his wife waits. As he reaches for her, a blow falls: he is dead, his body swinging beneath the…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "He felt his head emerge; his eyes were blinded by the sunlight; his chest expanded convulsively, and with a supreme and crowning agony his lungs engulfed a great draught of air, which instantly he expelled in a shriek!" What does "engulfed" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: engulfed: swallowed up completely.
10. Reread: "How coldly and pitilessly—with what an even, calm intonation, presaging, and enforcing tranquillity in the men—with what accurately measured intervals fell those cruel words:" What does "pitilessly" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: pitilessly: without pity or mercy.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" suggest about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A celebrated experiment with time and point of view; the twist depends on shifting from objective to subjective narration.
2. Find one example of structure in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Look for how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

3. How does the point of view in this story shape what we understand about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “What he heard was the ticking of his watch” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5): Slowed time. On point of view: Part I is objective, like a camera; Part III moves deep into Farquhar's mind, so the reader shares his illusion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “The man who was engaged in being hanged was apparently about thirty-five years of age.”, why might Bierce have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Peyton Farquhar, a Southern planter, stands on a railroad bridge in Alabama about to be hanged by Union soldiers. Part II flashes back: a disguised Union scout tempted him to try burning the bridge. In Part III the rope seems to break; he swims, dodges bullets, and walks all night to his home,…
6. As the opening story, what does “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge” set up that the rest of An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36): The rope. On structure: Three parts: the present (the execution), a flashback (the scout's trap), and the escape, which turns out to be imagined. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “Peyton Farquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37): The reality. Theme link: the whole escape happens in a moment. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Time can feel slow or fast. When has a moment seemed to last forever?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with illusion and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “What he heard was the ticking of his watch” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5): Slowed time. Theme link: the whole escape happens in a moment. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Background: Bierce fought for the Union at Shiloh and Chickamauga; the story (1890) is in Tales of Soldiers and Civilians. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36): The rope. Theme link: the whole escape happens in a moment. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A celebrated experiment with time and point of view; the twist depends on shifting from objective to subjective narration.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “Peyton Farquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37): The reality. Theme link: the whole escape happens in a moment. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “What he heard was the ticking of his watch” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5): Slowed time. Theme link: the whole escape happens in a moment. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36): The rope. On point of view: Part I is objective, like a camera; Part III moves deep into Farquhar's mind, so the reader shares his illusion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “Peyton Farquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37): The reality. Theme

link: the whole escape happens in a moment. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to war and death: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Bierce need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “What he heard was the ticking of his watch” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5): Slowed time. Theme link: the whole escape happens in a moment. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the structure in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.STR] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36): The rope. On structure: Three parts: the present (the execution), a flashback (the scout's trap), and the escape, which turns out to be imagined. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge” treats the mind's final escape at the moment of death with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “Peyton Farquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37): The reality. Theme link: the whole escape happens in a moment. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve illusion and reality? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “What he heard was the ticking of his watch” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5): Slowed time. On foreshadowing: The ticking watch, his heightened senses and the dream-like road all hint that the escape is unreal. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: “As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36): The rope. Theme link: the whole escape happens in a moment. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Ambrose Bierce about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Useful evidence: "Peyton Farquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37): The reality. Theme link: the whole escape happens in a moment. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Structure:** look for how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Point of view**: who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where is Farquhar at the start?

   A. In a boat

   B. In prison

   C. On a railroad bridge about to be hanged

   D. On his plantation

   Key: C (On a railroad bridge about to be hanged)

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37: "Peyton _____ was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side"

   Key: Farquhar

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36: "As he is about to clasp her he feels a _____ blow upon the back of the neck"

   Key: stunning

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Farquhar seem to experience in Part III?

   A. A battle

   B. A pardon

   C. An escape home to his wife

   D. A trial

   Key: C (An escape home to his wife)

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why is he being executed?

   A. He stole horses

   B. He deserted the army

   C. He tried to interfere with the railroad bridge

   D. He shot an officer

   Key: C (He tried to interfere with the railroad bridge)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “How softly the turf had _____ the untraveled avenue—he could no longer feel the roadway beneath his feet!” Word bank: pitilessly, engulfed, carpeted, inhaled

   Key: carpeted

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the truth at the end?

   A. He escaped

   B. He has died by hanging

   C. He was pardoned

   D. He dreamed the hanging

   Key: B (He has died by hanging)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who tempted him to attack the bridge?

   A. A slave

   B. His wife

   C. A Confederate general

   D. A Federal scout disguised as a Confederate soldier

   Key: D (A Federal scout disguised as a Confederate soldier)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The intervals of silence grew progressively longer; the delays became _____.” Word bank: inhaled, pitilessly, engulfed, maddening

   Key: maddening

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The sound of a clear, high voice in a monotonous _____ now rang out behind him and came across the water with a distinctness that pierced and subdued all other sounds, even the beating of the ripples in his ears.” Word bank: singsong, pitilessly, engulfed, inhaled

    Key: singsong

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “What he heard was the ticking of his watch” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Slowed time.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge”?

    A. Greed that grasps more than a person needs

    B. The foolishness of wishing to be young again

    C. The mind's final escape at the moment of death

    D. A crime that backfires

    Key: C (The mind's final escape at the moment of death)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The rope.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36).

Sample answer: Part III stays in his mind, with heightened sound ("What he heard was the ticking of his watch"); the switch to the present tense ("As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow") and the objective last line expose the illusion.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Peyton Farquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The reality.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how perception and time develops from an earlier story to “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: the whole escape happens in a moment.
17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Evidently this was no vulgar _____.”
    Word bank: assassin, pitilessly, inhaled, engulfed
    Key: assassin
18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5: “What he heard was the _____ of his watch”
    Key: ticking
19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge”? Part I is objective, like a camera; Part III moves deep into Farquhar's mind, so the reader shares his illusion.
    A. Point of view
    B. Metaphor
    C. Alliteration
    D. Characterization

    Key: A (Point of view)
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The rope.
21. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge”? Three parts: the present (the execution), a flashback (the scout's trap), and the escape, which turns out to be imagined.
    A. Personification
    B. Metaphor
    C. Structure
    D. Symbolism

    Key: C (Structure)
22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “What he heard was the ticking of his watch” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Slowed time.
23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

Sample answer: Part III stays in his mind, with heightened sound ("What he heard was the ticking of his watch"); the switch to the present tense ("As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow") and the objective last line expose the illusion.

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “As he shook his head free from the commotion of the smitten water he heard the deflected shot humming through the air ahead, and in an instant it was cracking and smashing the branches in the forest beyond.”, what does “smashing” most nearly mean?

    A. breaking into pieces

    B. without pity or mercy

    C. breathed in

    D. swallowed up completely

    Key: A (breaking into pieces)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The trees upon the bank were giant garden plants; he noted a definite order in their arrangement, inhaled the fragrance of their blooms.”, what does “inhaled” most nearly mean?

    A. breathed in

    B. without pity or mercy

    C. breaking into pieces

    D. swallowed up completely

    Key: A (breathed in)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He felt his head emerge; his eyes were blinded by the sunlight; his chest expanded convulsively, and with a supreme and crowning agony his lungs engulfed a great draught of air, which instantly he expelled in a shriek!”, what does “engulfed” most nearly mean?

    A. without pity or mercy

    B. breaking into pieces

    C. breathed in

    D. swallowed up completely

    Key: D (swallowed up completely)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 1, 5, 2, 10, 9, 18, 3, 7, 11, 13, 12, 15, 19, 14, 20	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 18, 7, 5, 3, 4, 8, 2, 12, 11, 13, 14, 19, 21, 22, 23	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	17, 5, 10, 18, 3, 9, 6, 13, 12, 11, 21, 15, 14, 19, 16, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	2, 9, 10, 17, 18, 4, 13, 11, 12, 21, 19, 15, 14, 23, 22, 20	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	6, 24, 3, 25, 5, 12, 11, 13, 21, 19, 14, 15, 23, 22, 20, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	2, 10, 24, 3, 4, 12, 13, 11, 19, 21, 14, 15, 22, 16, 23, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	3, 8, 26, 25, 18, 13, 12, 11, 21, 14, 15, 19, 16, 23, 22, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	10, 9, 3, 6, 1, 11, 13, 12, 14, 15, 21, 19, 22, 16, 23, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	6, 26, 8, 7, 3, 12, 13, 11, 15, 19, 21, 14, 20, 22, 16, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	10, 5, 7, 8, 18, 12, 11, 13, 15, 14, 21, 19, 22, 20, 23, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge,” how does Bierce show the mind's final escape at the moment of death? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the structure you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; AP: see unit standards): In An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, how does Bierce develop the idea of the mind's final escape at the moment of death? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the structure in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge develops the idea of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how the structure of An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (where it begins, turns and ends) and its structure shape the reader's understanding of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Two readers disagree about what An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge suggests about the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's structure and point of view), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Ambrose Bierce uses structure in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge to complicate the reader's understanding of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Situate An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the mind's final escape at the moment of death responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; AP: see unit standards): Read An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the mind's final escape at the moment of death follows or bends those conventions, using the structure as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; AP: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge and its treatment of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's structure and point of view, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge as evidence for a larger claim about the mind's final escape at the moment of death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge.

SAT-style questions

1. *The trees upon the bank were giant garden plants; he noted a definite order in their arrangement, inhaled the fragrance of their blooms.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “inhaled” most nearly mean?

   A. unbearable

   B. breathed in

   C. rules governing socially acceptable behavior

   D. a murderer

2. *The man who was engaged in being hanged was apparently about thirty-five years of age. He was a civilian, if one might judge from his habit, which was that of a planter. His features were good—a straight nose, firm mouth, broad forehead, from which his long, dark hair was combed straight back, falling behind his ears to the collar of his well-fitting frock-coat. He wore a mustache and pointed beard, but no whiskers; his eyes were large and dark gray, and had a kindly expression which one would hardly have expected in one whose neck was in the hemp. Evidently this was no vulgar assassin. The liberal military code makes provision for hanging many kinds of persons, and gentlemen are not excluded.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge”?

   A. The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

   B. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

   C. Racial pride destroying love

   D. The mind's final escape at the moment of death

SAT key: 1. B (breathed in); 2. D (The mind's final escape at the moment of death)

Unit test

An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Middle School and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why is he being executed?
   A. He stole horses
   B. He deserted the army
   C. He tried to interfere with the railroad bridge
   D. He shot an officer

   Key: C (He tried to interfere with the railroad bridge)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The intervals of silence grew progressively longer; the delays became _____.” Word bank: inhaled, pitilessly, engulfed, maddening
   Key: maddening
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the truth at the end?
   A. He escaped
   B. He has died by hanging
   C. He was pardoned
   D. He dreamed the hanging

   Key: B (He has died by hanging)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Farquhar seem to experience in Part III?
   A. A battle
   B. A pardon
   C. An escape home to his wife
   D. A trial

   Key: C (An escape home to his wife)
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where is Farquhar at the start?
   A. In a boat
   B. In prison
   C. On a railroad bridge about to be hanged
   D. On his plantation

Key: C (On a railroad bridge about to be hanged)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Evidently this was no vulgar _____."
   Word bank: assassin, pitilessly, inhaled, engulfed
   Key: assassin
7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37: "Peyton _____ was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side"
   Key: Farquhar
8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36: "As he is about to clasp her he feels a _____ blow upon the back of the neck"
   Key: stunning
9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "How softly the turf had _____ the untraveled avenue—he could no longer feel the roadway beneath his feet!" Word bank: pitilessly, engulfed, carpeted, inhaled
   Key: carpeted
10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The sound of a clear, high voice in a monotonous _____ now rang out behind him and came across the water with a distinctness that pierced and subdued all other sounds, even the beating of the ripples in his ears." Word bank: singsong, pitilessly, engulfed, inhaled
    Key: singsong
11. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who tempted him to attack the bridge?
    A. A slave
    B. His wife
    C. A Confederate general
    D. A Federal scout disguised as a Confederate soldier

    Key: D (A Federal scout disguised as a Confederate soldier)
12. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5: "What he heard was the _____ of his watch"
    Key: ticking
13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge"?
    A. Greed that grasps more than a person needs
    B. The foolishness of wishing to be young again
    C. The mind's final escape at the moment of death
    D. A crime that backfires

    Key: C (The mind's final escape at the moment of death)
14. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The rope.
15. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "What he heard was the ticking of his watch" (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Slowed time.

16. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge”? Three parts: the present (the execution), a flashback (the scout's trap), and the escape, which turns out to be imagined.

    A. Personification

    B. Metaphor

    C. Structure

    D. Symbolism

    Key: C (Structure)

17. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge”? Part I is objective, like a camera; Part III moves deep into Farquhar's mind, so the reader shares his illusion.

    A. Point of view

    B. Metaphor

    C. Alliteration

    D. Characterization

    Key: A (Point of view)

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “What he heard was the ticking of his watch” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 5) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Slowed time.

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36).

    Sample answer: Part III stays in his mind, with heightened sound ("What he heard was the ticking of his watch"); the switch to the present tense ("As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow") and the objective last line expose the illusion.

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Peyton Farquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 37). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The reality.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow upon the back of the neck” (An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, paragraph 36) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The rope.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how perception and time develops from an earlier story to “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: the whole escape happens in a moment.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Bierce uses point of view to trick the reader into sharing Farquhar's illusion.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: Part III stays in his mind, with heightened sound ("What he heard was the ticking of his watch"); the switch to the present tense ("As he is about to clasp her he feels a stunning blow") and the objective last line expose the illusion.

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “How coldly and pitilessly—with what an even, calm intonation, presaging, and enforcing tranquillity in the men—with what accurately measured intervals fell those cruel words:”, what does “pitilessly” most nearly mean?

    A. without pity or mercy

    B. swallowed up completely

    C. breaking into pieces

    D. breathed in

    Key: A (without pity or mercy)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He felt his head emerge; his eyes were blinded by the sunlight; his chest expanded convulsively, and with a supreme and crowning agony his lungs engulfed a great draught of air, which instantly he expelled in a shriek!”, what does “engulfed” most nearly mean?

    A. without pity or mercy

    B. breaking into pieces

    C. breathed in

    D. swallowed up completely

    Key: D (swallowed up completely)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “As he shook his head free from the commotion of the smitten water he heard the deflected shot humming through the air ahead, and in an instant it was cracking and smashing the branches in the forest beyond.”, what does “smashing” most nearly mean?

    A. breaking into pieces

    B. without pity or mercy

    C. breathed in

    D. swallowed up completely

    Key: A (breaking into pieces)

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The trees upon the bank were giant garden plants; he noted a definite order in their arrangement, inhaled the fragrance of their blooms.”, what does “inhaled” most nearly mean?

    A. breathed in

    B. without pity or mercy

    C. breaking into pieces

    D. swallowed up completely

    Key: A (breathed in)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 12, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 3, 4, 9, 11, 7, 10, 5, 2, 12, 8, 15, 14, 13, 16, 19, 20, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	3, 1, 6, 2, 5, 11, 8, 12, 10, 7, 14, 15, 13, 16, 19, 17, 18, 21	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	10, 6, 2, 8, 12, 1, 5, 3, 9, 13, 15, 14, 19, 17, 20, 16, 22, 18	

		recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	10, 12, 7, 4, 3, 8, 5, 6, 15, 13, 14, 19, 17, 16, 20, 21, 22, 23	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	5, 1, 2, 24, 25, 9, 11, 14, 15, 13, 17, 16, 20, 19, 21, 22, 18, 23	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	7, 26, 6, 5, 9, 27, 4, 13, 14, 15, 17, 16, 20, 19, 23, 18, 22, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	27, 11, 26, 5, 9, 6, 8, 14, 13, 15, 20, 19, 16, 17, 23, 22, 18, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	6, 26, 8, 11, 1, 2, 25, 15, 13, 14, 19, 17, 20, 16, 21, 22, 18, 23	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	8, 7, 5, 26, 10, 4, 12, 15, 14, 13, 20, 17, 19, 16, 21, 22, 18, 23	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	12, 3, 8, 7, 11, 26, 27, 15, 13, 14, 16, 20, 19, 17, 21, 23, 22, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Ambrose Bierce develops illusion and reality across An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to war and death.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of time. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Middle School 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Illusion and reality

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge teaches about illusion and reality. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Ambrose Bierce develops illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Ambrose Bierce develops illusion and reality across An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of illusion and reality. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Ambrose Bierce's choices in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of illusion and reality, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge's treatment of illusion and reality in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: War and death

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge teaches about war and death. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Ambrose Bierce develops war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Ambrose Bierce develops war and death across An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of war and death. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Ambrose Bierce's choices in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of war and death, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge's treatment of war and death in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Time

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge teaches about time. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Ambrose Bierce develops time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Ambrose Bierce develops time across An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of time. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Ambrose Bierce's choices in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of time, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge's treatment of time in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary or Wiktionary, 2026-10-20); unverified ones are left out. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.